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Squeezing THE Square

The real threat to Harvard Square isn't just growth, but the danger it'll become like everywhere else

Above: The people may change, but the Out-of-Town Newsstand in Harvard Square is always teeming with life.

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By Robert Campbell

Is Harvard Square outgrowing its own success?

It's a question being asked a lot in Cambridge these days, as the Square continues to boom. If there's a recession in this country, you'd never know it from looking at Harvard Square.

Six buildings are under construction or have just been finished. They include a hotel, two office-retail complexes, a block-long Harvard dormitory, a museum and a mixed-use development sponsored by the Catholic Church. Three more projects have all necessary approvals and are ready to start as soon as someone comes up with financing. That makes nine. A 10th is in the design stage. All this comes on top of what had been, already, a rapidly growing Harvard Square.

One small index of popular concern: The three proposals that have their approvals got them only after surviving legal assaults led by citizens' groups.

New buildings, though, are just the beginning of the changes in store for Harvard Square. Other aliens are on their way. What's being touted as the largest record store in the United States, for example, is about to open in a new building known as One Brattle Square. The store will occupy 20,000 square feet, which is more than half the area of a football field. It will be the colonial outpost of a British chain called HMV, a reference to the old RCA Victor slogan "His Master's Voice."

In London, they say that whenever you see an entire street glowing pink, you can be sure you've located an HMV store. That's because HMV typically flashes its pink neon trademark from each and every window. Somewhere Joe McCarthy must be giggling his weird giggle at the thought of a pinko Harvard Square. His spectral glee might be short-lived, however: The neon hasn't been approved for Cambridge.

As if the nation's biggest record emporium weren't enough, the biggest that now exists in the Boston area – Tower Records – is launching a second-front invasion of the Square via Mount Auburn Street, in the old Charrette store.

We're only scratching the surface. It's possible to

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Robert Campbell is the Globe's architecture critic.

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go on almost endlessly, citing the major changes that are facing Harvard Square. But the new buildings and record stores can stand for all the others.

What's happening to the Square? Should it be happening? What should be done about it, if anything?

Not simple questions.

Just about everyone loves Harvard Square. Punks, professors, merchants, shoppers. Everyone flocks there. Perhaps, as critics maintain, we love the Square so much we're about to hug it to death. But what people love may not always be quite what they think they love. There's a paradox about Harvard Square that has to be understood.

An intense urban experience

What is truly loved – though we don't always admit it – is the Square's congestion. We love the way the Square piles one option on top of another, weaving just about every possible kind of person and activity into a tightly patterned, vividly colored urban quilt. Americans are starved for that kind of intense urban experience. If you ask them, Americans always say they want peace and quiet and flowers and trees. But if you watch them, you see most of them gravitating to the spot where the action is. That's Harvard Square.

You can define a city, a real city, as a place where the most happens in the least amount of space. What the urban thinker Lewis Mumford once called "a rich, many-sided, exuberant, life-sustaining habitat, teeming with biological fulfillments and cultural possibilities."

By that measure, Harvard Square is heaven. It's the best little downtown in America. In a few blocks, it packs an incredible punch of vitality.

Look at the stats. Bookstores, for instance: There are 17 in Harvard Square. All of them sell actual printed books: no college beer-mugs or T-shirts. Probably there are entire states in this country that can't count 17 real bookstores. And the bookstores are radically differentiated: Some are for new books, and some are for used, and there's one each for comic books, foreign books, rare books, Asian books, radical books, art books and so on. None belongs to a national fast-food-for-the-soul chain, like Barnes & Noble or B. Dalton or Waldenbooks. Not yet.

Or take restaurants: Depending on how you figure, the Square can boast at least 50 of them. They're differentiated, too, including just about every price range and ethnicity. They range from the reliable old Tasty Sandwich Stop, which feels like a 1940s diner buried in a building, to such recent additions as Troyka, a Russian restaurant. None is a McDonald's or Kentucky Fried Chicken or Roy Rogers. Yet.

Variety and people in motion

Around and above all the commerce, a lot of people quietly go about their work. Especially architects, for some reason. At its mid-1980s peak, the Square's offices housed at least 500 functioning architects. Also lawyers, dentists, tailors, dressmakers, accountants, engineers, photographers, brokers, shrinks, the works. People live in Harvard Square, too, more than ever before, and not only students. Posh condo kings line the Charles River while a homeless man roams the streets as he's done for more than a decade. Not fairness, of course, but variety.

Crowds, action, choice – those are the things that make Harvard Square terrific. Living, working, eating, reading, all in the same place. Gathering in movie lines, or at the outdoor cafes, or around the street performers. Watching one another do those things.

If action is good, why isn't more action better? Why is everyone so worried about all the new growth in the Square?

There's a very good reason. Harvard Square is losing its uniqueness. It's becoming homogenized.

What was once an engaging mix of modest brick buildings and converted wood-frame houses – a jumble of differences – is growing more and more to look the same. A sort of standardized Harvard Square building has emerged. It has two levels of shops at the sidewalk and office space above. It's made of red brick, with maybe limestone, so it will remind you of Harvard. It's being plopped down everywhere in the Square. There's far more red brick in the Square today than there ever was historically. Harvard Square is rapidly becoming, architecturally, a caricature of itself. An urban logo. One dreads the day when the last row of kinky three-deckers, still painted in their gaudy '60s stripes, will disappear from the scene.

Physical sameness. That's one problem. Another problem is a lot more serious. It's cultural sameness.

Harvard Square is losing its cultural uniqueness because higher and higher rents are driving out the small-time locals who once operated the Square's shops and services. In their place come big national or international chains who can afford to foot the new bills. Those record stores. Chain clothing outlets, like The Gap. Just last month, a local corner flower shop was displaced by a branch of Elizabeth Arden, elegantly designed to purvey cosmetics.

Sameness – and its consequences

Harvard Square is changing from the unique downtown of a unique city into a regional shopping center that soon may not be very different from Chestnut Hill or Burlington Mall. It will be the same row of the same shops selling the same stuff to the same market. It won't be that different from Denver or Dallas. Just as you can go anywhere in the world today and stay in a Holiday Inn where there will be, as the ad says, "No surprises," you'll find no surprises in Harvard Square.

If that happens, who will bother to come? Given the parking problem in Harvard Square, why would people shop there when they can go to the mall for the same stores? Even from a strict business point of view, the change from local to global in the Square seems shortsighted.

Thus the Square really does have a problem. Unfortunately, people often focus on its non-problems instead.

One such is the size of new buildings. Neighbors of Harvard's new hotel at the juncture of Harvard Street and Massachusetts Avenue fought hard and successfully to cut its height by a story. Now that the hotel has been finished, it's clear it would have looked as good, and probably better, if it had been a little taller: a prominent landmark anchoring a prominent site. Controls on size in Harvard Square could maybe be a little tighter here and there. But thanks to an aggressive city planning department, they're pretty good.

Another red herring is open space. Harvard Square's residents are lucky enough to luxuriate between the endless greenway of the Charles River on one side and the marvelous spaces of Harvard Yard and Cambridge Common on the other. Not to mention several pocket parks. Yet they spend an astonishing amount of their time bitching about a lack of open space. Green commandos work to fill every urban cranny with chlorophyll, regardless of whether it's likely to be used or maintained. Cambridge isn't a green suburb like Lexington. To push it in that direction is merely to sap it of its true urban character.

The real ogre of Harvard Square isn't bulky buildings or lack of space. It's sameness. The endless ooze of red brick. The monotony of the national chain store.

There is a possible way to fight such an ogre.

To find it, we have to go back a little bit into history.

The influence of Bertha Cohen

It is a striking truth that nobody used to worry about growth in Harvard Square. Nobody, that is, until the proposal came along, around 1970, to build a Kennedy Presidential Library on the old MBTA yards where Boylston Street (now JFK Street) meets the river. That proposal was the Sarajevo of what has become a 20-year war between the juggernauts of growth and the gentle believers that Small is Beautiful. The gentle people won (by fighting fiercely), and the library was banished to uncomplaining Columbia Point. Abandoned, its site became a park.

But until the library, there was no concern. Until 1978, there wasn't even a height limit in most of the Square. No one bothered to block even so massive an intrusion as Harvard's Holyoke Center – even though, appalling as it may seem today, that this concrete megastructure was intended by its architect as only the first in a row of similar behemoths. Only in the 1970s began the confusing blizzard of zoning laws, design-review boards and litigious citizen groups that now govern growth in the Square.

There's a reason the issue of growth didn't come up before it did, and the reason has a name. The name is Bertha Cohen.

Cohen was an inconspicuous Russian immigrant who owned 33 properties in Harvard Square when she died in the early 1970s. She'd picked them up cheap in the Depression. Unaware of the Square's commercial potential, she kept her rents low.

At Cohen's death, her entire estate was bought by a single broker, who immediately began selling chunks off to entrepreneurs. Commercial rents, in some cases, tripled almost overnight. The Square was off on a binge that has never stopped.

The quiet Harvard Square of Bertha Cohen is still, for many people, an image of Eden. Such people – this writer is one – remember fondly the college-town atmosphere, not unlike that of Williamstown or Hanover today. The sleepy bookstores. The tweedy clothiers. Cronin's tavern on Dunster Street, its walls covered with oars and lacrosse sticks and fading beer-stained photographs of Harvard crews and teams. The three big cafeterias, where, for the price of an English muffin and a cup of tea, you could argue about Marx or Sartre all night.

The thing to notice is that the Bertha Cohen Square was a subsidized Square. Cohen was underwriting it by artificially holding it below its earning potential. In that sense, it was unreal, as fake in its way as Disneyland. And there wasn't only Cohen. Other property owners were also conservative. Gun-shy from vacancies they'd suffered during a decades-long Boston area depression, they were happy to rent their space – their storefronts and offices – at moderate rates to reliable long-term tenants. Many of these tenants were the owners' family friends, relationships that went back for generations. The Square was a village whose proprietors weren't about to opt for cataclysmic change.

In a Square thus subsidized by the modest ambitions of its property owners, it was possible for low-rent occupants – laundries, drugstores, cafeterias and diners, used-book stores – to flourish. New businesses could seed themselves in Harvard Square cheaply then, too, and many did.

Subsidy is the key word. It's a nasty one in polticial terms. But if people really want to preserve the variety of the Square, the city government may have to bite the bullet and play the part of Bertha Cohen.

What Cambridge can do

The city could experiment, for instance, with commercial rent control, as San Francisco has done in an effort to preserve the diversity and character of some of its neighborhood business centers. Rent control for apartments already exists in Cambridge, and it's admittedly been a can of worms for everyone concerned. Yet it's probably helped prevent the city from turning into a yuppie version of Georgetown.

Cambridge could also restrict the amount of street frontage allowed to be assembled by any one owner, as Philadelphia has proposed to do in certain neighborhoods. That might be a way of preserving the Square's typical clutter of smallish buildings, as opposed to the wider, more monotonous new ones.

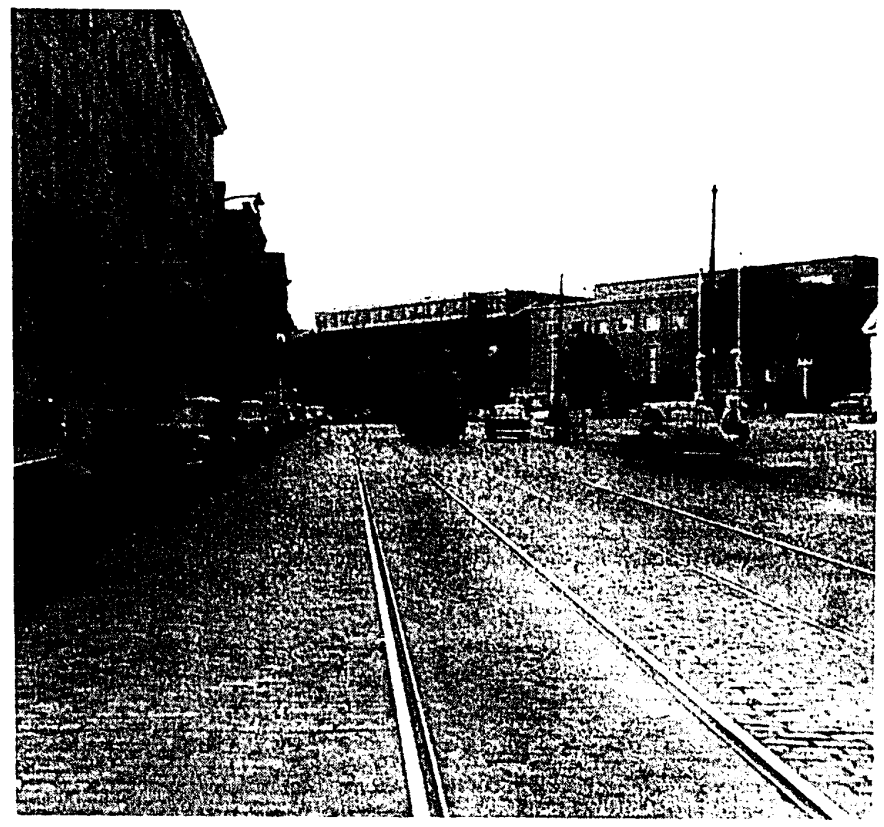
Already Cambridge is applying one kind of subsidy to improve the visual character of Harvard Square. The Cambridge Historical Commission has cut deals with some of the owners. The owner agrees to restore a building's facade to its historic character – gradually, over time, as tenants change – and the city in return reduces the building's tax assessment.

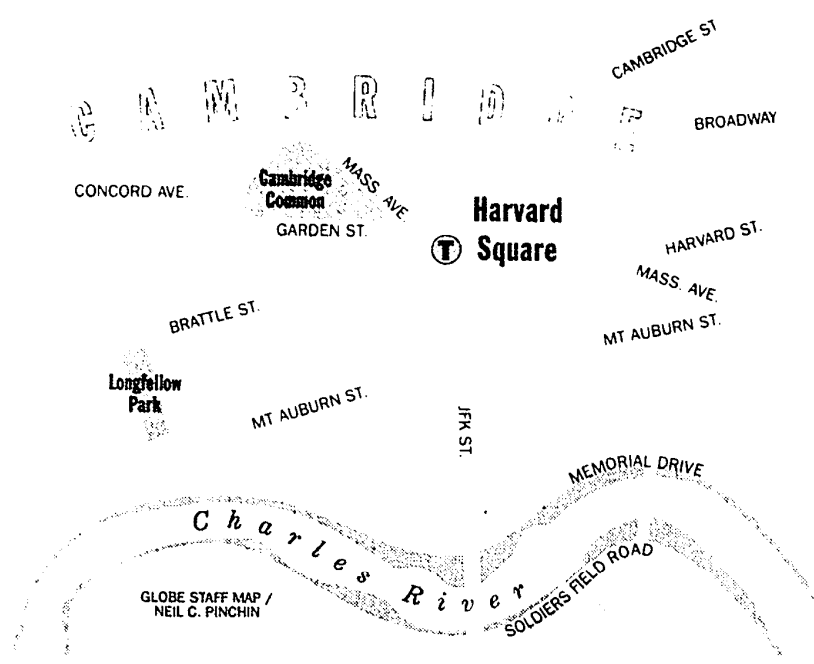
Perhaps there are other equally simple, equally creative forms of subsidy. Diversity is the quality above all others that makes Harvard Square what it is, and it's clear that the random action of an unfettered free market is no longer likely to maintain that diversity.

There's a larger significance to all this. It isn't only Harvard Square that's threatened by sameness. So is the whole world. Don't look for a favorite corner bistro in Paris; it's probably a McDonald's today. If one unique chunk of real estate in Cambridge can find a way to keep itself different, it can be a lesson for a planet that is hell-bent on homogenization.



Above, the Inn at Harvard, one of six new Harvard Square building projects. Below, Massachusetts Avenue approaching Harvard Square, in 1949; the white building barely visible on the right is the site of the Inn at Harvard.





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